

DCAT-US 3.0 and federal statistics: was FCSM’s input included?

Brock Webb, U.S. Census Bureau. 8 October 2026.

Bottom line: partly. The Federal Committee on Statistical Methodology (FCSM) publicly asked for seven of the eight statistical needs in the table below. In DCAT-US 3.0 none of the seven is Mandatory. One, restricted-access terms, is Recommended. Four are Optional fields that agencies may leave out, the link that marks a dataset as part of a series was dropped, and the published page does not settle where dimensions landed. [8][9][10][12][18][19][20]

1. What DCAT-US 3.0 is

DCAT-US 3.0 is the federal standard for the catalog card, or metadata, that describes each government data asset listed publicly on Data.gov. [4][5][6] It is the United States version of the World Wide Web Consortium’s Data Catalog Vocabulary (DCAT). [1][2] The Office of Management and Budget (OMB) memorandum M-25-05 directs each agency to update its comprehensive data inventory listings to the DCAT-US 3.0 schema by September 30, 2026. [6][7]

2. Who made it

The General Services Administration says DCAT-US version 3.0 was built together by the Federal Chief Data Officers Council, FCSM, and the Data.gov team. [4][5] Their joint effort is the FAIRness Project (FAIR: findable, accessible, interoperable and reusable). [3]

3. What FCSM asked for, and where it landed

Statistical need	Asked for by FCSM?	Level in DCAT-US 3.0 (page of 5 October 2026)	Result
series	Yes [8]	Dropped (the series link) [9][10][11]	Dropped
dimensions (breakdowns such as place, item, time)	Yes [12]	Not confirmed	Different form ; level not confirmed
units of measure	Not confirmed	No field for the data’s unit; unitMeasure gives the unit of a quality score [15]	No field ; FCSM ask not confirmed
uncertainty (margins of error)	Yes [12]	Optional [9][10]	Optional only
methodology and provenance	Yes [8][12]	Optional [9][10]	Optional , and different form
revisions and versions	Yes [12][18]	Optional [9][10]	Optional ; form not checked
quality dimensions	Yes [18]	Optional [9][10]	Optional , and different form
restricted-access terms	Yes [8][12][19][20]	Recommended [1][9][10]	Recommended ; form not checked

What the results mean:

- **Optional only:** it has a field in 3.0, but agencies may leave it out.
- **Recommended:** agencies are expected to fill it; it is not required.
- **Dropped:** it was in the 2025 working draft and is not in the published 3.0.
- **No field:** 3.0 has no field for it.
- **Different form:** the international standards (StatDCAT-AP, the European statistical version of DCAT, and W3C vocabularies) carry it differently from how FCSM asked for it. Section 4 gives each case.
- **Not confirmed / not checked:** the source check could not confirm that part.

4. Where the standards carry it differently

FCSM’s A Framework for Data Quality says documentation should include methods used in processing, imputations, weighting, editing, integration methods, and data dictionaries. [8][18] Data on the Web Best Practices (2017) intends that people learn a dataset’s origin and history and that computer programs process this provenance automatically. [17] DCAT Version 3 says quality dimensions are characteristics that matter to users, sets no required list, and leaves implementers to choose their own. [2][16] StatDCAT-AP and the W3C Data Cube vocabulary name each breakdown, such as place or time, as its own field in the record. [13][14]

Whether FCSM left out something the standards call for cannot be shown from the public record while the project’s sequencing plan is unpublished.

5. A path forward

Europe built StatDCAT-AP, an add-on to its data catalog standard for describing statistical datasets, which the European Commission says improves the quality of published dataset records. [13]

Proposed next step (the author’s). The federal statistical system could do the same: adopt a statistical profile of DCAT-US 3.0 as a community standard, endorsed by the Interagency Council on Statistical Policy (ICSP). The profile names which of 3.0’s Optional fields statistical agencies fill and adds the few statistical fields 3.0 lacks, on StatDCAT-AP’s model. It stays optional for the government at large and is expected practice for statistical data.

Checking it is automated. DCAT-US 3.0 is published as a machine-readable JSON Schema, and agencies can check their metadata against it with Data.gov’s online validator or the published validation script. [1] Both are programs that report records that do not conform, not checklists. A statistical profile can be published the same way, as a stricter schema, and checked by the same programs.

6. What the public record cannot show

The FAIRness Project’s two-year sequencing plan went to OMB and was not published; a 2024 public request remains unanswered. [21]

AI use in this document

Generative AI made a meaningful contribution. It located passages in the source documents, drafted the summary sentences from them, checked each sentence against the passage it cites, and laid out this version from the author's direction. Sentences the check could not confirm were removed, not reworded. The models were Anthropic's Claude Opus 5, Claude Opus 4.8, Claude Sonnet 5 and Claude Fable 5.1, used through Claude Code under a commercial subscription, 5 to 8 October 2026. The author reviewed and approved the content and is responsible for it. The passage behind every statement is quoted in the companion detail file and the questions-and-answers attachment of 5 October 2026.

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